

Vibhuti Mehta

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Placement Director: Kelly Bishop (Kelly.Bishop@asu.edu)

Placement Coordinator: Laura Talts (ltalts@asu.edu)

EDUCATION

Arizona State University Ph.D. in Economics	2021-2027
University of Wisconsin–Madison M.S. in Economics	2019-2021
Birla Institute of Technology & Science (BITS), Pilani B.Sc. in Economics	2012-2016

RESEARCH FIELDS

Labor Economics, Health Economics, Education Economics

REFERENCES

Esteban Aucejo (Chair) Professor Department of Economics Arizona State University Esteban.Aucejo@asu.edu	Alvin Murphy Associate Professor Department of Economics Arizona State University alvin.murphy@asu.edu	Samuel Young Assistant Professor Department of Economics Arizona State University sammygyoung@gmail.com
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WORKING PAPERS

“Licensing Barriers to Interstate Mobility: Evidence from Travel Nurses” (*Job Market Paper*)

This paper examines the impact of licensing barriers to interstate mobility on nursing labor markets and health outcomes during the COVID-19 pandemic. Using county-level CDC data, I exploit spatial variation from the Nurse Licensure Compact (NLC) and temporal variation from federal emergency waivers to identify the causal effects of licensing barriers on COVID-19 mortality. Through a Boundary Discontinuity Design, I establish that NonNLC States reported 7% higher deaths per capita in 2020, despite emergency measures already in place. To establish the mechanism, I use granular data on US travel nurses and their individual licenses. I estimate a structural model of nurse applications that separates the direct disutility of licensing barriers from hospitals’ wage responses. The results reveal that a lack of licensure reduces application probability by 70%, despite the presence of a compensating wage premium and emergency measures. Counterfactual estimates reveal that NonNLC states suffered the highest loss in applications due to licensing barriers. Together, the findings highlight that interstate licensing barriers constrained the rapid reallocation of critical healthcare labor during the pandemic and that uniform licensing policies like the NLC can enhance labor market responsiveness and improve public health resilience in times of crisis.

“Universal Vouchers and the Composition of Public School Exits: Evidence from Arizona” (*with Esteban Aucejo and Alex Toy*)

In 2022, Arizona became the first state to make its Education Savings Account (ESA) program available to every K–12 student. Using administrative records on all Arizona public school students from 2016 to 2023, we examine who used an ESA during the first year of universal eligibility and whether the expansion changed who left the public school system. Students receiving special education services were about 1.7 percentage points more likely to use an ESA - more than twice the overall take-up rate of 1.5 percent. Among racial and ethnic groups, White

students had the highest take-up. To separate changes in selection from preexisting patterns, we compare students leaving public schools before COVID-19, during the pandemic, and after the expansion. Students receiving special education services stand out: they were already more likely to leave, and this gap doubled after the expansion.

“The Impact of School Quality Grades on Student Transfers and Universal Voucher Uptake” *(with Esteban Aucejo and Alex Toy)*

Arizona assigns every public school an A-F grade and, since 2022, has made public funding available to all families seeking alternatives outside the public school system. We examine how these grades affect students’ decisions to leave public schools and whether the universal expansion of the Empowerment Scholarship Account (ESA) program changed this response. Using administrative data on all Arizona public school students from 2016 to 2023, we employ a regression discontinuity design comparing schools just above and below the letter-grade cutoffs. Before COVID-19, schools narrowly receiving a higher grade had an exit rate 0.5 percentage points lower than those narrowly receiving a lower grade, relative to an average of 8.3 percent. Preliminary results suggest that this gap disappeared during the pandemic and remained absent after the ESA expansion.

ACADEMIC PRESENTATIONS

ASU PhD Reunion Conference	2026
Annual Health Econometrics Workshop	2026
Policy Research Workshop, Institute for Humane Studies (IHS)	2026
Western Economic Association International (WEAI) - Graduate Student Workshop	2026
American Society of Health Economists (ASHEcon)	2025, 2026
Western Economic Association International (WEAI)	2024
Arizona State University - General Economics Workshop	2024, 2025, 2026

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Arizona State University

Research Assistant for Esteban Aucejo	2024-Present
Research Assistant for Ellen P. Green	Summer 2024
Research Assistant for Paula Calvo	Summer 2023

University of Wisconsin-Madison

Research Assistant for Rikhil R. Bhavnani	2020
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TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Arizona State University, Instructor

Applied Regression and Data Analytics	Spring 2026
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Arizona State University, Teaching Assistant (selected)

Gender and Family Economics	Spring 2023, 2025
Applied Regression and Data Analytics	Fall 2023, 2024
International Trade Theory	Spring 2024

EMPLOYMENT

Credit Suisse Business Analytics Limited, India

Economic Research Analyst	2016-2019
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ADDITIONAL INFORMATION

Languages: English, Hindi (Native)

Programming: Stata, R, Python, MATLAB, Qualtrics, L^AT_EX